

Crisis Vulnerability Checklist

From **My PR Partner**.

Powered by CRC Public Relations, a trusted crisis & PR advisory firm.

Help future-proof your organisation by identifying areas of vulnerability and risk that can lead to reputational damage. This is by no means an exhaustive list, but it is a great start.

How to use this checklist

- 1 **Answer each item honestly** using one of the four responses below.

YES Totally complete and functioning

OK Somewhat, but needs improvement

NO Not at all, or not working

N/A Does not apply to my organisation

- 2 **Consider with your team** how you can address the areas where you answered NO or OK. If these are not addressed, you may be more vulnerable to a crisis that can damage your reputation.
- 3 **Crisis preparation and PR support is available through CRC Public Relations.** Please contact us for assistance in any area of vulnerability that involves PR or communications. For areas that require advice from experts in other fields, we recommend you contact us first to discuss your reputational vulnerabilities, so you are better informed when speaking to those specialists.

Key points about the areas of vulnerability

- While many areas of vulnerability may lead to financial loss and create other challenges, this checklist is designed specifically to identify issues that could lead to a crisis that impacts trust, resulting in serious or long-term damage to your reputation.
- Severe reputation loss can be directly linked to major material impact, including internal and external conflict, loss of focus and time, stress and mental health issues, and loss of revenue.

Remember, while risk cannot be eliminated, many issues and crises can be avoided by reducing areas of vulnerability. Planning now saves time, stress and finances later.

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THE CHECKLIST

Fifteen areas of vulnerability.

Mark the response that best reflects your organisation today, not where you hope to be.

1 Culture and Core Values

The foundation that helps protect your reputation.

YES OK NO N/A

- All staff are aware of, and can quote, your values and mission.

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

2 Communication

Ensure your stakeholders are advocates, not adversaries.

YES OK NO N/A

- Your entire staff understand the ramifications of poor communication.
- All major communications are vetted and proofed by at least one other person before sending.

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3 Media

You cannot hide from the media, so look for opportunities.

YES OK NO N/A

- You have a procedure to manage incoming media enquiries.
- All staff have a written copy of your media policy and adhere to it.
- Your spokespeople are trained in effective media interviews.

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4 Social Media

A two-edged sword that needs to be managed.

YES OK NO N/A

- Access to official social media accounts is limited to appointed, trained staff, and a policy is in place.
- You have a written social media policy for all staff that covers personal social media use.

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5 Online Reviews

What others say online is now used by AI in search results.

YES OK NO N/A

- You regularly monitor online reviews and respond, particularly to all negative reviews.

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6 Emergency Management Plan

How you act and communicate through an event will affect your reputation.

YES OK NO N/A

- You have an emergency management plan covering natural disasters, active shooters and other emergency situations, which has been tested and all staff are aware of their roles.

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7 Crisis Communications Plan

Often it is not how you handle a crisis that is the problem, it is how you communicate.

YES OK NO N/A

- You have an issues and crisis communications plan, separate to but aligned with your emergency plan, that considers all scenarios (beyond emergencies) in which you need to quickly communicate to your key stakeholders, or wider through the media.
- You have a relationship with an external crisis specialist who you can call upon to provide communications and media support in the midst of a crisis or major issue.

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8 Complaint and Issues Escalation

If you do not resolve an issue, it is likely to end up on social media or in the news.

	YES	OK	NO	N/A
• You ensure no staff or customer grievance or complaint is ignored or unresolved, and have an escalation procedure to handle unresolved complaints which includes clear timelines.	☐	☐	☐	☐
• All staff know the procedure for escalation of complaints and ensure that it is strictly followed.	☐	☐	☐	☐

9 Staff Policies

Staff grievances are a major source of issues, and many can be avoided.

	YES	OK	NO	N/A
• You have written and stated workplace policies around harassment, bullying, health and safety, grievances and others that may lead to staff issues.	☐	☐	☐	☐
• You have a written whistleblower policy that protects staff who report misconduct, wrongdoing, or safety concerns through appropriate channels.	☐	☐	☐	☐
• All employment contracts for staff include clear codes of conduct, social media policies, and confidentiality obligations that protect your organisation's reputation.	☐	☐	☐	☐
• You have a defined investigative process for complaints against a staff member, along with a written standard operating procedure.	☐	☐	☐	☐
• Your policy includes ways to deal with staff under investigation, and to support complainants who may be victims through the process.	☐	☐	☐	☐

10 Board

A difficult area for leadership.

	YES	OK	NO	N/A
• If applicable, you have a written code of conduct for board members that all directors sign upon appointment.	☐	☐	☐	☐
• All board members understand the difference between governance (the board role) and management (the executive role). A board charter articulates these responsibilities, and procedures exist to address board members who cross this boundary.	☐	☐	☐	☐

11 Regulatory Compliance

Proactive compliance that prevents crises.

	YES	OK	NO	N/A
• If applicable, you have designated persons responsible for compliance in each area, with clear reporting lines documented in position descriptions.	☐	☐	☐	☐

12 Data Security

Data breaches happen every day, and they can happen to any organisation.

	YES	OK	NO	N/A
• You have sought independent advice and support to ensure your systems are protected against cyber-attacks to best-practice standards.	☐	☐	☐	☐
• You have cyber insurance that covers not only data breaches, but communications.	☐	☐	☐	☐

13 Social Engineering

Any of your staff can be targeted.

YES OK NO N/A

- | | | | | |
|--|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|
| • You have sought independent advice to establish best-practice standards to minimise the risk of your staff being victims of social engineering techniques. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| • You have strict policies and procedures around requests to change bank account details, and other personal details of staff, suppliers and other stakeholders. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| • You are engaging in ongoing education in this area, including AI generated fraud, to ensure you are always vigilant and protected. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |

14 Marketing

Great marketing ideas can backfire.

YES OK NO N/A

- | | | | | |
|---|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|
| • Your marketing strategy process always considers possible adverse public relations implications. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
| • You seek outside perspectives before launching public marketing campaigns and messages, to ensure any messaging risks are assessed. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |

15 Reception Team

Your front line PR people.

YES OK NO N/A

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|---|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|
| • Your reception, and anyone who may be the first point of contact with your company, are trained on how to manage angry or abusive calls, and to deal with media enquiries in accordance with your media policy. | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ | ☐ |
|---|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|

Where to focus next

We encourage you to seek advice with appropriate specialists in the areas above if you have identified areas of vulnerability. If you require assistance with communications, public relations and crisis preparedness, please contact CRC Public Relations.

The My PR Partner Crisis Masterclass is Australia's premier crisis communications online course and 12-month program.

CONTACT US FOR MORE INFORMATION

MY PR PARTNER CRISIS MASTERCLASS

Be ready before a crisis hits.

Our premier online course and 12-month program prepares your organisation and your people to communicate with confidence when it matters most. Contact us for more information.

CALL US

1300 182 186

EMAIL

info@myprpartner.com

ONLINE

myprpartner.com

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